



The Selectboard
TOWN OF WESTHAMPTON
TOWN HALL
1 SOUTH ROAD
WESTHAMPTON, MASSACHUSETTS 01027

Minutes of the Meeting
Monday, December 1, 2025, 6:00 PM
at the Town Hall, 1 South Road

A regular meeting of the Westhampton selectboard was held on Monday, December 1, 2025, 6:00 PM, at the Town Hall, 1 South Road. The meeting was held as a hybrid meeting via Zoom teleconferencing.

The meeting was called to order at 6:03 PM.

Present:

Present: Susan Bronstein, Scott Johndrow, Jennifer Milikowsky.

Also present: Mr. Doug Finn

6 PM - Executive Session: Open Meeting Law Complaint

Acknowledge receipt of open meeting law complaint from Scott Johndrow against Susan Bronstein and Jennifer Milikowsky, dated November 18, 2025; Acknowledge and review complaint and discuss response; votes may be taken.

It was MOVED by Bronstein, SECONDED by Milikowsky

Pursuant to G.L.C. 30A, §21(a)(1), to enter into executive session for the purpose of acknowledging receipt of an Open Meeting Law Complaint, and review and discuss proposed response.

VOTED: MILIKOWSKY: YES; JOHNDROW: YES; BRONSTEIN: YES (6:05 PM)

Executive Session Minutes

The board acknowledged receipt of an open meeting law violation filed by Mr. Scott Johndrow. A proposed response as drafted by K&P Law was distributed for review.

After review, it was MOVED by Milikowsky, SECONDED by Bronstein

To approve the draft response, and to authorize K&P Law to send the response.

VOTED: MILIKOWSKY: YES; BRONSTEIN: YES; JOHNDROW: ABSTAIN. (2, 0, 1, 6:11 PM)

It was MOVED by Milikowsky, SECONDED by Bronstein

To exit executive session, and to stand in recess until 7 PM.

VOTED: MILIKOWSKY: YES; BRONSTEIN: YES; JOHNDROW: YES. (3, 0, 0, 6:11 PM)

7 PM - Resume in Open Session / Call to Order

The Selectboard resumed in open session at 7:01 PM.

7 PM - Interview – Tax Collector – Patricia Cotton

The Selectboard will conduct an in-person interview. Votes may be taken.

The board conducted a brief interview with Patricia Cotton, who has applied for the vacant position of Tax Collector.

Ms. Bronstein noted receipt of the application from Ms. Cotton, and asked for input from board members.

Mr. Finn noted that the town had received only one other application for the position; that applicant did not appear to have municipal experience; their work experience was only within the private mortgage and banking industry; they appeared to have little to no experience in the town government; they appeared to have little to no experience doing tax collection.

Ms. Bronstein noted that it was highly unlikely that another qualified applicant could be found, appointed, and prepared to serve in the position within the limited time that the town had to fill the position, nor would the Town find anyone who knows Westhampton better, or has served Westhampton better.

There being no further discussion, it was MOVED by Milikowsky, SECONDED by Bronstein,

To appoint Patricia Cotton to Tax Collector for a term to commence on December 15, 2025.

VOTED: 3, 0, 0. (7:04 PM)

7 PM - Public Hearing - Tax Classification

In accordance with Section 56 of Chapter 40 of the General Law, the Westhampton Selectboard will conduct a public hearing on the question of adoption of percentages of the total tax levy to be borne by each class of real property (residential, open space, commercial, industrial) and personal property for Fiscal Year 2026. All interested parties are invited to attend and will be heard.

Ms. Bronstein read the public notice, and opened the public hearing at 7:06 PM. The Chair recognized Mr. David Zagorski for a brief presentation.

(Correspondence as received from the Assessors is included as an amendment to these minutes)

Mr. Zagorski noted the Board of Assessors' recommendation:

- A Single Tax Rate for all classes of property
- No Open Space Discount
- No Residential Exemption
- No Small Commercial Exemption

The floor was opened to public comment, with comments focused on:

Understanding the town's high tax rate

Several commenters sought clarity about why Westhampton's mill rate is higher than many surrounding communities. Board explanations and public discussion highlighted:

- Westhampton's small tax base, with fewer total properties than nearby towns.
- The effect of state-determined property values and lower home values compared to eastern Massachusetts.
- The impact of state formulas for aid, which consider per-capita income rather than municipal revenue capacity.

Desire for transparency and context

Residents expressed appreciation for the detailed explanation of how the tax rate is set, how appropriations drive the levy, and how state aid offsets play a role.

General agreement on continuing a single tax rate

Comments did not express a desire to split the tax rate between property classes.

The consensus was that Westhampton's low percentage of commercial/industrial property does not support a split rate. The recommendation for a single rate was broadly supported and accepted.

The board confirmed that a single tax rate would apply to all property in Westhampton (residential,

commercial, industrial, agricultural).

After final review, It was MOVED by M: Milikowsky, 2: Johndrow

To accept recommendations of Assessors.

VOTED: 3, 0, 0 (7:15 PM)

7:15 PM – Public Hearing - Complete Streets Policy

The Selectboard will hold a public hearing on December 1, 2025, 7:15 PM at the Town Hall to receive and consider comment on a proposed “Complete Streets Policy”. The draft policy is available for public inspection on the Town website, www.WesthamptonMA.gov or in person at the Town Hall during regular business hours. All interested parties are invited to attend and will be heard.

The public hearing was opened at 7:15 PM.

A presentation was made by Ms. Teri Anderson, Chair of the MVP Committee and the Road Safety Subcommittee. Ms. Anderson noted that, through the development of the Master Plan, many residents expressed concern about:

- Pedestrian and bicycle safety
- Dangerous curves or intersections
- Limited walkability or ADA access in certain areas
- Areas where traffic calming might improve conditions

She noted that, as a result, the Master Plan identified roadway safety as a high priority for residents.

A number of commenters emphasized their desire to Preserve the Rural Character of the Town, noting that

- Westhampton’s small-town character is important;
- no interest in urban-style infrastructure such as extensive sidewalks, heavy signage, or major reconfigurations, and
- a preference for “low-impact” improvements that maintain the town’s feel.

Concerns were raised that state-funded programs in other communities have introduced changes that residents perceived as unnecessary or disruptive. Many commenters wanted reassurance that the town retains full control of any proposed improvements.

Some participants asked for clarity, and reassurance that

- The policy itself does not mandate any specific project.
- Future projects will require separate public review.
- The town can opt out of any project or grant if it is not a good fit.
- There are no deadlines requiring rapid movement into later stages of the program.
- Funding for planning work (Tier 2) is provided by the state and does not raise local taxes.

This discussion eased some concerns that adopting the policy could force the town into unwanted construction or binding commitments.

There was some discussion about what types of projects might ultimately qualify. Examples discussed included:

- A safer pedestrian route between the Town Hall parking area and the library
- ADA-compliant curb cuts
- Selective crosswalks in high-use areas
- Targeted traffic-calming where crashes or near-misses have occurred
- Tree replacement in areas losing mature street trees

Many residents emphasized wanting **small-scale, context-appropriate** improvements rather than sweeping changes.

There was a strong interest in:

- Continued public meetings
- Input from residents in developing the Tier 2 prioritization plan
- Ensuring the planning process is responsive to community preferences
- Making sure any future design work reflects local conditions and character

Mr. Johndrow, and Mr. Bill Jablonski, Highway Superintendent, noted their objection to implementing the policy. Mr. Jablonski specifically noted that additional oversight was neither requested or needed.

It was MOVED by Milikowsky, SECONDED by Bronstein

To adopt Complete Streets Policy. (8:23 PM)

After review, and further deliberation, Ms. Bronstein withdrew her second and Ms. Milikowsky withdrew the motion.

(MOTION WITHDRAWN. 8:28 PM)

Ms. Anderson further noted that recommendations from the Street and Safety Committee had been left out of the final version of the policy, and asked if the board could discuss those recommendations. However, given the time, the chair suggested that the public hearing be closed, and the matter tabled for the time being. Ms. Bronstein thanked participants for attending. No further action taken.

(8:33 PM)

Police Ad Hoc Study Committee

Mr. John Shaw presented a verbal and written final report, and asked that the committee be dissolved.

After review of the final report document, it was MOVED by Milikowsky, SECONDED by Johndrow

To accept the report with the Town's thanks, and to dissolve the Police Ad Hoc Study Committee.

VOTED: 3, 0, 0. (8:44 PM)

Elyse Campbell, Chair, Recreation Committee - update:

Ms. Campbell noted that the committee currently consists of six members, two of which are high school students. Three meetings have been held. No new programs have been suggested or recommended as of yet. Basic committee structures are still being determined, and the Town's Town Hall use policy is being reviewed. The committee is also reviewing the Open Space and Recreation Survey.

Ms. Campbell noted no formal requests for activities have yet been received; however, a future CPR training class is being lightly considered.

Generally, Ms. Campbell noted that the first few meetings have focused on town policies and how to move forward. The next meeting of the Recreation Committee is scheduled for December 15.

Highway Dept - Bill Jablonski:

Mr. Jablonski provided an update on recent work from first week in October:

Repairs to equipment

CEMTERY - headstone foundations, monument placement, some burials.

GENERAL: leaf blowing and catch-basin work, all road mowing completed; addition of excavator worked well; 450 hours to mow all roads in town;

Mr. Jablonski noted that the new grader is purchased; some repairs were necessary (somewhat expected); the new grader will make a significant difference; two machines were graded this fall; a vibratory roller was rented to help with gravel roads, and made a significant difference;

The transfer station was prepped and cleaned for the DEP inspection, all mowing around transfer station, highway dept, landfill completed. All DEP inspections passed with no comments. Mr. Jablonski noted that the DEP uses the Westhampton transfer station as a model throughout the HRMC.

A significant amount of gravel hauled to gravel roads to improve them; dust control added.

Mr. Jablonski noted that they had spent a couple days on Spruce Hill; Tob Hill Road to Spruce Hill Road, and Spruce Hill Road can now be plowed.

Townwide: plow whips, marking road edges for snow plow drivers, are in place.

There was some discussion relative to the Southampton Road Intersection study; some changed signs will be needed;

VRU Survey – Southampton Road at Main Road

Mr. Jablonski noted the results of the Vulnerable Road User survey and assessment completed by the Pioneer Valley Planning Commission; he noted that many of the recommendations from the survey – mostly related to upgrades to existing signs, or new signs -- are in the works, with one or two either outside the scope of the Town, or not feasible at this time.

Mr. Jablonski was thanked for his time.

Committee Report: Board of Health

Ms. Katch Bachelor provided a brief update on staffing and operations of the Foothills Health District, and described current operations as continuously improving.

No action taken.

Policy Review – Public Agenda Policy

A revision to the public agenda policy was reviewed.

It was MOVED by Milikowsky, SECONDED by Johndrow

To approve the revised policy as amended, and to sign.

VOTED: 3, 0, 0. (9:14 PM)

Discussion – Budget 2027 Process

Selectboard will review draft materials and may issue guidance for budget development.

A draft letter to Town Departments and Committee heads was reviewed. Mr. Finn will distribute to departments, boards and committees as soon as possible.

Review of Correspondence if any

Correspondence was reviewed. No action taken on any item.

Unanticipated Business

Mr. Aaron Bauer asked about the status of a way known as Fisher Lane - is it a town road? is it still a public way? Mr. Finn will research and report back to the board.

Ms. Milikowsky noted that, based on her findings, should the town wish to 'leave' the Hampshire County Group Insurance Trust, the town must give at least 90 days notice; however, the town can ONLY leave the trust at the end of any given fiscal year – June 30. Ms. Milikowsky recommended seeking confirmation of this information with the Town Treasurer.

AP and Payroll Warrants

After review, it was MOVED by Johndrow SECONDED by Milikowsky

To approve Accounts Payable Warrant #W26-11 and Payroll Warrants WP26-11.

VOTED: 3, 0, 0. (9:22 PM)

Minutes

After review, it was MOVED by Johndrow SECONDED by Bronstein

To approve minutes of November 17, November 19 and November 21, as presented.

VOTED: 3,0, 0 (9:26 PM)

Other Deliberation

There was some discussion about the manner and timing of public notification of the public hearings in a "Facebook" group called 'What's Up Westhampton', with Ms. Milikowsky noting that such postings were not regular, and that the notice stirred up significant feedback and some controversial comments and feedback. Mr. Finn agreed to put public meeting notices only on the town's website.

Adjourn

It was MOVED by Johndrow, SECONDED by Milikowsky
To Adjourn.

VOTED: 3, 0, 0. (9:37 PM)

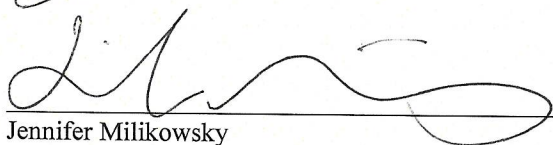
Approved by a vote of the Selectboard at a regular meeting, held on December 15, 2025.



Susan Bronstein



Scott Johndrow



Jennifer Milikowsky